



Force of habit: After its 250th F1 victory, Ferrari now sits a close second to Mercedes in the Constructors' Championship this season. AFP

the option I chose. The feeling was back where it needs to be. I'm so incredibly happy."

Hamilton, after a string of strong results, started the weekend on a strong note, clinching pole for the sprint race and looking good for a record-extending 10th win at Silverstone.

However, his main race unravelled with a five-second penalty for a false start, while a late pit stop meant the 41-year-old had to settle for third.

Ferrari's title rival, Mercedes, experienced a much more challenging weekend.

Championship leader Kimi Antonelli was unlucky not to come away with the win after finishing first in the sprint race and qualifying on pole for the main Grand Prix.

The Italian was overtaken off the line by the fast-starting Ferraris but went for the overcut to recover lost ground and gain track position.

The 19-year-old was on course to retake the lead from Leclerc with fresher tyres, but on Lap 41, Antonelli suffered front-left wheel shield damage, which severely compromised his ability to turn the car through the corners and dropped him out of the points.

While Antonelli was left rueing his

bad luck, his teammate George Russell capitalised on a slice of good fortune to finish second on the road.

Starting fifth on the grid, Russell lacked the pace of his teammate and, to make matters worse, suffered a puncture during a thrilling battle for the final podium spot with Hamilton and Red Bull's Max Verstappen in the early stages of the race. But Antonelli's issues and Verstappen's race-ending crash on Lap 48 paved the way to the podium for the Briton.

The safety car finish and Hamilton's late pit stop, anticipating a final dash to the line, further helped Russell climb a place and close the gap to Antonelli at the top of the drivers' standings to 25 points. Amid all the chaos, Leclerc kept his composure out front to register a crucial win and get his campaign back on track.

"Tough times never last, only tough people last," Leclerc exclaimed over the radio after taking the chequered flag.

It was a statement that conveyed his self-belief was back and that his dream of one day becoming Ferrari's next World Champion — a mantle Leclerc has carried ever since arriving in Maranello in 2019 — was well and truly alive.

MotoGP

Ducati's Marc Marquez ruled the roost with a flawless ride at the German Grand Prix to claim his 10th Sachsenring MotoGP victory. The seven-time MotoGP champion led from start to finish to cap off a memorable weekend in which the Spaniard also won the sprint race. Marquez now sits third in the standings, just 18 points behind championship leader Jorge Martin.

Formula 2

ART Grand Prix driver Kush Maini (**below**) finished third in the Formula 2 feature race at Silverstone, adding to his sprint race win at the Barcelona-Catalunya circuit a month ago. Starting third on the grid, Maini displayed strong pace in the opening phase of the race, building a substantial gap over Campos Racing's Nikola Tsolov in second. However, the 25-year-old's resistance came to an end on Lap 20 when he was overtaken by Tsolov. Maini dropped another place on the penultimate lap to VAR's Rafael Villagómez to finish third. He is currently sixth in the drivers' standings with 63 points.

